

Renegers or Zealots?

The Causal Effect of Radical Right Opposition Parties on Government Anti-Immigration Pledge-Fulfillment

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1. Introduction

Recent years have seen an increase in scholarly attention on the impact of opposition parties and electoral competition dynamics on government pledge fulfillment (see e.g., Horn and Jensen 2017; Jensen and Seeberg 2015). While models of pledge fulfillment have been greatly enriched by such work two critical elements of the party competition dynamics of pledge fulfillment remain un-addressed. First the impact of opposition parties on government-pledge fulfillment has not as yet been causally identified; leaving open the question of whether variation in pledge-fulfillment is indeed a result of changes party competition or simply a function of shifts in voter opinion and preference dynamics or larger confounding shocks.
Secondly, recent scholarship has largely focused on effects across the ideological left-right divide; systematically ignoring the impact of fringe parties and competition dynamics among ideological proximate party subsets. I propose to address this gap in the literature via a Regression Discontinuity Design; exploiting electoral thresholds and tight electoral margins across 68 elections, 31 years and 21 countries as a source of plausibly exogenous variation to identify the causal effect of radical right parliamentary opposition parties on the degree of over-/under-fulfillment on government anti immigration pledges. My contribution to the literature is twofold. First, I identify the causal impact of opposition parties on pledge fulfillment showing tentative evidence of an overall decrease in anti-immigration pledge fulfillment as a result of radical right parliamentary presence. Second, I explore variation in the aforementioned party competition dynamics, showing that while left leaning governments under-deliver on anti-immigration pledges as a result of exposure to radical right opposition parties, right leaning governments over-deliver. Given the the recent global resurgence of right-wing parties and anti-immigration sentiment it seems more critical than ever to empirically address if and how right-wing ideological contagion effects translate into real policy; making this work of interest to scholars and practitioners alike.

2. Theory

2.1 Established Theories of Party Competition and Pledge-Making

A growing literature has been considering party competition dynamics in pledge-making (see e.g., Costello 2025; Håkansson and Naurin 2016). This has largely focused on pledge-making as a form of auction politics. In an environment of increasing voter volatility and highly professionalized as well as mediatized politics; parties as rational office seeking agents are highly incentivized to buy votes from prospective utility maximizing voters through expansive promises (Håkansson and Naurin 2016). This expansive prospective signaling is tempered by the risk of retrospective punishment by voters in the next election cycle for having over-promised and under-delivered on goods voters had come to expect (Costello 2025). Parties therefore engage in a strategic competition to maximize reward and minimize punishment by outbidding their competition w.r.t a maximally expansive yet achievable policy agenda. In this sense these theories may be seen as an extension to the large issue competition literature (see e.g., Green-Pedersen 2007; Aragonès, Castanheira, and Giani 2015; Hobolt and De Vries 2015). While offering a compelling theory of pledge-making behavior, this strand of the literature emphasizes competition dynamics in prospective pledge-making over those in retrospective pledge-fulfillment; and can thus offer no clear account of how governments (parties) behave when in office (parliament).

2.2 Established Theories of Party Competition and Pledge-Fulfillment

A somewhat newer and smaller strand of the pledge-fulfillment literature addresses the above gap (see e.g., Horn and Jensen 2017; Jensen and Seeberg 2015; Thomson et al. 2017). These theories have largely focused on the opposition's ability to influence policy through agenda setting and challenging the government by highlighting its shortcomings in policy fields where the opposition holds the issue ownership advantage (Horn and Jensen 2017; Jensen and Seeberg 2015). As parties compete over an increasing pool of median swing voters across the left-right positional divide, the opposition effectively holds asymmetric power as it is in a position to highlight the government's failings, emphasizing why swing voters should switch camps, while not being held responsible for delivering policy solutions (Horn and Jensen 2017; Thesen 2013). The opposition is thus in a position to selectively increase the probability of retrospective punishment of the government in the next election cycle, while bolstering its ownership of and perceived competence on key policy issue, thus increasing the probability to gain prospective votes (Thomson 2011; Stiers and Dassonneville 2024 for a comprehensive treatment of the effect of biases and issue ownership on perceived party competence and pledge fulfillment). While offering a more complete account of how party competition shapes the government's ability to follow through on election pledges; these theories critically hinge on opposition parties being viable alternatives to governing parties, thus constraining competition dynamics under investigation to those between major parties across the left-right divide. Consequently the effect of smaller fringe parties and competition dynamics among ideologically proximal vs distant government-opposition-dyads have as yet been underexplored.

2.2 Towards an integrated Theory connecting Party Competition, Voter Perception & Pledge-Fulfillment

I attempt to bridge the gap between pledge-making and pledge-fulfillment theories of electoral competition by focusing on the party competition dynamics induced by radical right parties. By constraining my theoretical lens to pledge-fulfillment dynamics on immigration issues (a core issue owned by the radical right (Williams and Hunger 2022)); I aim to derive a more focused, integrated theory of party competition, voter perception and pledge fulfillment. The following theoretical exposition rests on five relatively standard assumptions.

1. Parties are both office and policy seeking
2. Governments are resource (time) constrained
3. Voters are utility maximizing agents
4. Voters are able to assess their level of realized utility
5. Parties cannot accurately predict voter behavior

Given that parties are office and policy seeking and governments are resource constrained we should expect 0 over or under performance w.r.t pledges under perfect conditions. If a government has achieved an ideal pledge level; any degree of over performance on a given issue must necessarily come at the expense of another and consequently incur retrospective punishment by voters. Why then do we observe substantial differences between pledged and delivered outcomes and how do radical right opposition parties shape these fulfillment differentials? Under this theory there are three core mechanisms explaining over and under fulfillment. I will discuss each mechanism in turn and derive resulting hypotheses at the end.

Under-Fulfillment:

1. over-promising to gain votes
2. strategic issue de-prioritization

Over-promising to gain votes is a mute mechanism in the context of close elections under investigation here. Intuitively the electoral competition dynamics under a scenario where a radical right party just barely falls short of vs crosses the parliamentary inclusion threshold should be virtually identical, meaning that the level of over-promising and subsequent pledge fulfillment challenges should be equal. Strategic issue de-prioritization on the other hand provides a more compelling theoretical argument. Should a radical right party cross the electoral inclusion threshold governing parties may strategically de-emphasize policy issues owned by the radical right in order to shift resources towards policy issues that are more aligned with their areas of competence. This maximizes fulfillment chances on core government agenda issues and thus minimizes retrospective punishment risk (Matthieß 2020) while simultaneously minimizing the risk of legitimizing the radical right's agenda and loosing more voters to it by a strategy of accommodation (Krause, Cohen, and Abou-Chadi 2023). This mechanism should be especially pronounced among more left-leaning governments. As an inverse corollary to this mechanism; should a radical right party fail to cross the electoral inclusion threshold, governing parties may be more inclined to invest resources into fulfilling pledges associated with radical right policy issues; as radical right parties are perceived as a lesser electoral threat and encroaching on their issue space is an effective means to stand out w.r.t competitor parties.

Over-Fulfillment:

1. securing votes through accommodation

Running contrary to the above mechanism; governments may choose to over-deliver on pledges associated with radical right policy issues when faced with a radical right party in opposition. Such behavior may be induced via two mechanisms. First the incumbent government perceives a strategy of accommodation as an effective means to undercut radical right support and gain votes (Spoon and Klüver 2021). Second through gaining parliamentary representation a radical right party unlocks substantial attention resources thus alleviating informational asymmetry w.r.t governments and voters (Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020; Horn and Jensen 2017). Whereas incumbent parties may be more able to get away with under-performance on core radical right agenda items without radical right party representation in parliament; once a radical right party crosses the inclusion threshold they unlock the means and incentives to put substantial pressure on the government to deliver on radical right agenda items (Horn and Jensen 2017; Thesen 2013). This mechanism should be especially pronounced among more right-leaning governments.

Hypotheses

H1: The presence of radical right parties in opposition decreases pledge-fulfillment on anti-immigration policies by incumbent governments.

H2: The higher (lower) the ideological proximity of the government to radical right opposition parties the greater the increase (decrease) in government anti-immigration pledge-fulfillment induced by the presence of radical right parties.

It should be noted that; given the substantial expected variation in effects and causal mechanisms based on the degree if ideological proximity of governments and radical right opposition parties it is difficult to state a hypothesis on the overall effect of radical right party oppositions on anti-immigration pledge fulfillment. Any such statement is necessarily contingent on one's relative degree of belief in the under- vs over-fulfillment mechanisms.

3. Methods

3.1 Data & Measurement

Two critical questions naturally arise in any attempt to formalize and measure pledge-fulfillment: 1. "What is a pledge?" and 2. "What constitutes fulfillment?". While seemingly innocuous, these questions present a major point of contention in the study of pledge-fulfillment, splitting attempts at definitions in the relevant literature along a spectrum ranging from more restrictive and formal approaches, defining pledges as binding commitments with clear, binary fulfillment criteria (Thomson et al. 2017), to more open and informal perspectives, which view pledges as political signals of intent and policy positioning with broader fulfillment conditions (Horn and Jensen 2017). While requiring that pledges come with measurable success criteria serves an academic need for clear cut operationalization; it divorces the concept from its political reality. Far from being clear cut, pledges are often vague and lack measurable success criteria (Horn and Jensen 2017). Moreover measurability appears to have little bearing on whether a statement is perceived as a pledge (Krishnarajan and Jensen 2022), suggesting that voters judge the performance of political actors by rather more expansive standards. Critically then, any work conceptualizing pledge-fulfillment behavior as an attempt to maximize electoral rewards must account both for how parties actually communicate pledges and how such pledges are in turn perceived by voters. Salience based issue emphasis measures are uniquely placed to address the above challenges; as they capture how parties communicate their ideological as well as policy positions to voters and how voters themselves conceive of pledge-making. Adopting the salience approach I operationalize pledges and fulfillment via the ratio of anti to pro immigration statements and legislation produced by parties respectively, thus allowing me to directly compare how signaled issue emphasis translates into realized, legislative issue emphasis. Following seminal work by (Horn and Jensen 2017) introducing the pledge gap methodology; I utilize MARPOR data to construct an immigration salience measure indicating the pro vs anti immigration stance that parties signaled to voters. The standard pledge gap methodology measures policy outputs using broad indices, which are often limited in within-country variance over time due to institutional path dependency and susceptible to policy-process external shocks. I refine this approach by leveraging *QUANTMIG* (Czaika 2023) data on over 6000 annotated laws and immigration policy changes to directly capture realized issue emphasis in legislative practice. I find signaled anti-immigration salience to be strongly predictive of restrictive immigration reform; i.e. governments that run on an anti-immigration platform deliver more restrictive legislation and visa versa. Substantial divergences in promised and realized anti-immigration policy do; however remain. Follwing (Horn and Jensen 2017), this pledge-gap, is my main outcome of interest.

3.1.1 Measuring Anti-Immigration Pledges

In order to capture the signaled anti vs pro immigration position of governing parties IP_p I utilize *MARPOR* (Lehmann et al. 2024) data and compute the log ratio of anti and pro immigration quasi-sentence shares in a given party's manifesto as suggested by (Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020) and (Lowe et al. 2011). This yields a party level index ranging from $[-\infty, +\infty]$ with positive (negative) numbers indicating a more anti-immigration (pro-immigration) position and 0 indicating a neutral position.

$$IP_p = \log\left(\frac{\frac{\sum(\text{anti})}{N} + 0.05}{\frac{\sum(\text{pro})}{N} + 0.05}\right) \tag{1}$$

I aggregate the positions of governing parties IP_p into a single government position IP_G via a seat-share weighted average to accurately account of differential party influence in coalition governments. Seat shares are derived from the *ParlGov* Database (Döring and Manow 2024).

$$IP_G = \sum_{p}^{P}(IP_p \cdot \tilde{w_p}) \tag{2}$$

$$w = \frac{\text{seats}}{\sum \text{seats}} \tag{3}$$

$$\tilde{w} = \frac{w}{\sum w} \tag{4}$$

MARPOR does not code an explicit pro or anti immigration indicator. While immigration specific party position data sets exist (see e.g. Parties' Immigration and Integration Positions Dataset *PImPo* (Lehmann and Zobel 2018)), they invariably exhibit insufficient spatio-temporal coverage to support my research design. I thus proxy anti immigration positions via the *per608* ('Multiculturalism: Negative') item and pro immigration positions via the *per607* ('Multiculturalism: Positive') item. While not a direct measure of immigration positions; the two items represent appeals to cultural protectionism; a core point of contention in immigration debates and critical element of the radical right agenda (Abou-Chadi 2016; Han 2015; Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020).

The testability of the theoretical argument advanced above critically hinges on two assumptions w.r.t anti-immigration pledges. Fist radical right opposition parties and governing parties or coalitions should differ meaningfully in their anti-immigration pledges to rule out the case that governments simply change their pledge-performance behavior when radical right parties enter parliament due to ideological alignment. Second right-wing governments should exhibit a higher degree of issue competition with radical right opposition parties on anti-immigration positions than left-wing governments; as this is the key driver behind the hypothesized heterogeneous effects of radical right parliamentary presence on anti-immigration pledge-fulfillment.

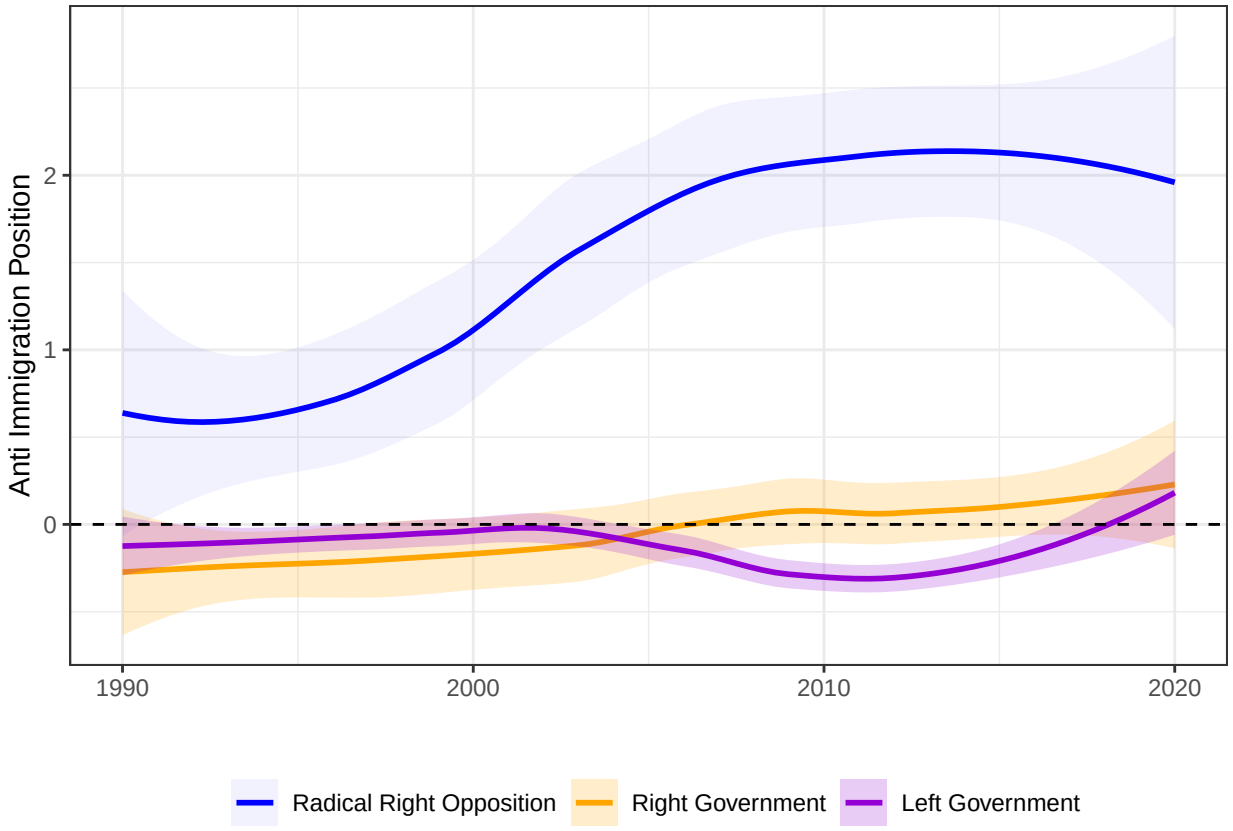


Figure 1: Anti Immigration Positioning

Figure 1 above substantiates these two assumptions. Note the clear positional differentiation between governments and radical right opposition parties as well as the sustained trend towards net anti-immigration positioning by right-wing governments.

3.1.2 Measuring the Pledge-Fulfillment Gap

Operationalizing government performance in delivering on an anti-immigration agenda hinges on accurate measurements of changes in the relative restrictiveness of immigration policy. While a myriad of comprehensive immigration policy indices have been developed Pemstein et al. (2025); they present a sub-optimal measure of pledge performance in this context for two core reasons. First substantial changes in immigration policy may be rare not due to a lack of political effort and will but simply due to the complexity and path dependency of the underlying policy regime; meaning that index variation over time will necessarily be limited. Second changes in the relative restrictiveness of an immigration policy regime may be subject to exogenous shocks, meaning that such changes may not be easily attributable to political actions. Conscious of these limitations I opt for a direct measure of anti vs pro immigration policy output. Utilizing *QUANTMIG* data on over 6000 annotated laws and policy changes pertaining to immigration I construct an equivalent salience measure to the one employed to operationalize pledges (see *EQ 1*). *QUANTMIG* categorizes each law as an immigration restriction increasing, decreasing or neutral policy change; allowing me to compute immigration

restrictiveness IR as the log ratio of the share of restriction increasing to restriction decreasing laws passed by a government.

$$IR = \log\left(\frac{\frac{\sum(\text{+restriction})}{N} + 0.05}{\frac{\sum(\text{-restriction})}{N} + 0.05}\right) \tag{5}$$

By measuring both promised and delivered anti-immigration policy on the same scale; this approach allows for direct and interpretable measurement of pledge-fulfillment on an intuitive scale. Additionally changes in this immigration policy measure are directly attributable to government action.

I follow Horn and Jensen (2017) and operationalize the degree of anti-immigration pledge-fulfillment as the difference between the realized and predicted degree of anti-immigration policy. Hence negative values represent under-fulfillment and positive values represent over-fulfillment.. More formally given a model f that predicts anti-immigration policy IR_{it} from anti-immigration positions $IP_{G_{it}}$ and a set of additional controls X:

$$IR_{it} = f(IP_{G_{it}}, X_{it}) + \epsilon \tag{6}$$

the degree of pledge-fulfillment of a government w.r.t its signaled policy position are the residuals ϵ of model f i.e. the degree to which anti-immigration policy has exceeded or fallen short of the level that would have been expected given the government's pledges. A strict conceptualization of validity of this measure critically hinges on the assumption that the model residuals ϵ uniquely represent pledge-fulfillment / breaking; meaning that all other confounding factors are captured in the controls X. The testability of the theoretical argument advanced above; however, merely relies on voter perception of pledge-fulfillment which arguably distinguishes less stringently between pledge-breaking attributable to government failure or exogenous circumstances outside the government's control (see e.g., Krishnarajan and Jensen 2022). The pledge-gap measure therefore feasibly aligns closely with actual voter perceptions of pledge-fulfillment.

I estimate a parsimonious year fixed effect panel model regressing the immigration policy measure IR_{it} on the pledge measure $IP_{G_{it}}$ for each country, government pair i in year t; while controlling for the government $i's$ left right position and the short term country specific migration context via net migration inflows in year t and $t-1$. Data on net migration flows comes from the *World Development Indicators* data-set (The World Bank n.d.) and left right positions are derived from *ParlGov* data which leverages the *Chappel Hill Expert Survey* (Rovny et al. 2024) for party position classification. The baseline pledge-gap model (*Table 1*) shows that anti-immigration pledges are a strong, statistically significant predictor of anti-immigration policy, substantiating the critical point that on average governments that pledge more restrictive immigration policy do deliver on it.

I make two note-worthy alterations to the pledge-gap model proposed by Horn and Jensen (2017). First I omit country fixed effects as a set of country specific intercepts risks over-controlling in a model relying on relatively small N, short, imbalanced panel data for estimation. Note; however that the main findings of the RDD models are robust to the inclusion of country fixed effects in the pledge-gap model. Second I

Table 1: Pledge-Gap Model

	Dependent variable:
	anti-immigration policy
anti-immigration pledge	0.597**
	(0.292)
net migration (million)	−1.773
	(1.345)
net migration lagged (million)	1.534
	(1.359)
government left-right position	0.019
	(0.071)
Year FEs	yes
Observations	498
R^2	0.164
Adjusted R^2	0.103
Residual Std. Error	2.580 (df = 463)
F Statistic	2.671*** (df = 34; 463)
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

predict residuals via a LOOCV cross-fitting procedure (Stone 1974), addressing a core endogeneity issue in the original model resulting from observations for which pledge-gaps are to be predicted being used in fitting the pledge-gap model itself. By fitting the residual model for observation i on all observations excluding i; I reduce the risk of biasing the predicted pledge-gap towards 0 in extreme cases. To align the predicted anti-immigration policy measure yet more closely with the interpretation of: "the level of anti-immigration policy a voter may reasonably expect the government to deliver based on its pledge signaling"; it would be preferable to additionally only predict residuals for observations in year t with a model fitted on data up to year $t-1$, but data sparsity prohibits this refinement.

3.2 Panel Data Construction

My unit of observation are country, government, year triads. I consider cabinet changes within a given election cycle that do not result in changes to the set governing parties as a single continuous government. This country, government, year panel spanning 21 countries, 111 governments and 31 years from 1990-2020 is constructed using *ParlGov* data. As data is missing for some country year observations and I exclude governments that included a radical right party by design the constructed panel is unbalanced. As *QUANTMIG* data on immigration legislation is only available on a year level; but elections may happen at any point during a given year, outcomes are not neatly attributable to specific government. I thus construct weights indicating the proportion of days for which a given government was in office for a given year.

3.3 Causal Identification using Electoral Thresholds

A myriad of factors ranging from shifting public opinion and media landscapes to economic as well as migration shocks jointly determine the probability of radical right parties gaining parliamentary representation and the degree of anti-immigration pledge-fulfillment by governments. This complex confounding makes disentangling the effect of radical right opposition parties from effects induced by contextual factors extremely challenging for standard models. In order to address these issues and identify the causal effect of radical right opposition parties on government anti-immigration pledge-fulfillment; I exploit electoral thresholds as a source of plausibly quasi random assignment of cases to *radical right party in parliament (treatment)* and *radical right party not in parliament (control)* conditions. While the difference between a radical right party moving from 0 to a minimum of 1 parliamentary seat may seem like a marginal difference-maker; achieving parliamentary representation endows radical right parties with considerable resources and media attention; and marks them as a relevant political challenger (Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020; Dinas, Riera, and Roussias 2015). We may thus reasonably expect governments to alter their behavior in response to radical right parties gaining parliamentary representation.

3.3.1 Estimation & Assumptions

Critically for the causal argument advanced here, the assignment rules induced by arbitrary, exogenous, institutional inclusion thresholds create natural, quasi random treatment assignments in close elections. Consider Germany and its 5% electoral threshold by way of example. Contextual factors in a world where a radical right party gains 5.01% vs one where it gains 4.99% of the national vote should intuitively be virtually identical i.e. any difference in pledge-fulfillment behavior of governments in world 1 vs world 2 should simply be a result of a radical right party having gained parliamentary representation in the former but not the latter. Stated more formally we make the plausible assumption that confounding variables U vary smoothly around the electoral threshold and the only thing that changes discontinuously in the limit of the electoral threshold is the treatment assignment. This is known as the continuity assumption (Hahn, Todd, and Van der Klaauw 2001; Lee and Lemieux 2010). The related, yet stronger, local randomization assumption posits that within a region around the electoral threshold, treatment is effectively randomly assigned and treated and control units do not differ significantly in confounding factors (Lee and Lemieux 2010). Given the deviation of radical right party vote shares from the electoral threshold as the treatment assignment variable A we can identify the local average treatment effect LATE at the treatment assignment cutoff $c = 0$ by:

$$\text{LATE} = \lim_{\epsilon \to 0^+} \mathbb{E}[Y_i \mid A_i = c + \epsilon] - \lim_{\epsilon \to 0^-} \mathbb{E}[Y_i \mid A_i = c + \epsilon] \tag{7}$$

As by definition either only treatment or control units exist precisely at the cutoff; $\mathbb{E}[Y_i \mid A_i = c]$ is estimated non-parametrically by extrapolation to the cutoff via flexible weighted regression models that assign higher weight to observations near the cutoff (Lee and Lemieux 2010).

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_i \mid A_i = c] = \beta AW + \epsilon \tag{8}$$

Fitting these models induces a comlex bias-variance tradeoff. Leveraging observations further from the electoral threshold c to fit the model yields lower variance but potentially higher bias estimates and visa versa. I thus rely on bandwidth optimization procedures introduced by (Imbens and Kalyanaraman 2012) for estimation. I additionally include an exhaustive set of controls, country as well as year fixed effects and country clustered standard errors in the full specification of my model.

One critical requirement substantiating the validity of an RDD design posits that there should infact be a noticable discountinuity in the outcome of interest around the cutoff. As observable in *Figure 2* below both a global *loess* (left) and local weighted *OLS* (right) fit show a clear discontinuity around the electoral threshold. Additional identifying assumptions and robustness tests are discussed in *Section 4.2*.

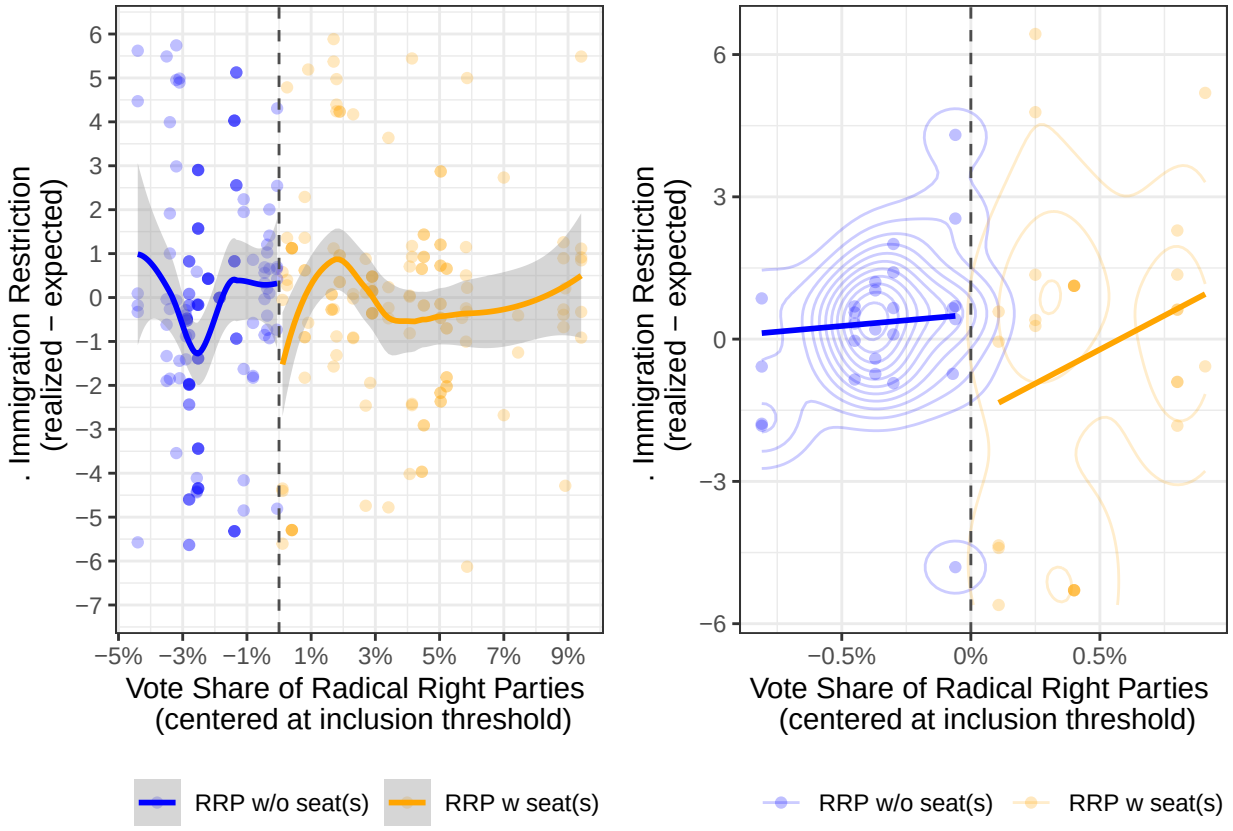


Figure 2: RDD Discontinuity Plot

3.3.2 Constructing Electoral Thresholds

Only a minority of countries make use of legally defined electoral thresholds. In order to extend my sample beyond this small subset of countries I follow work by (Abou-Chadi and Krause 2020) and calculate the 'threshold of inclusion' as proposed by (Taagepera 2002) for countries without a legally defined electoral threshold. The threshold of inclusion T is defined as

$$T = \frac{75\%}{\left(\left(\frac{\text{seats}}{\text{districts}}\right) \cdot \sqrt{(\text{districts})}\right)} \tag{9}$$

and represents the country specific average threshold at which parties have a 50/50 chance of winning their first seat (Taagepera 2002).

As this measure has been shown to be biased in plurality-majoritarian and mixed-member-majoritarian electoral systems by (Bischoff 2009), I exclude the aforementioned cases from my analysis. One additional concern is that even where legal electoral thresholds exist, the may not be the only institutional rule governing seat allocation, meaning that parties that fall below the legal threshold may still gain seats in parliament. No such cases; however exist in my data.

4. Results & Discussion

4.1 Main Findings

The first aim of this study was to test the relative merits of over- and under-fulfillment mechanisms. *Table 2* presents clear initial evidence favoring the under-fulfillment mechanism hypothesized in **H1**. The presence of a radical right opposition party decreases the pledge gap by approximately 2.5 points. Noting the baseline values shown in *Figure 2* it becomes clear that incumbent governments under-deliver w.r.t anti-immigration policy when confronted with a radical right opposition party; pointing to a strategic issue de-prioritization competition dynamic aimed at countering the radical right's issue ownership advantage and policy agenda. While the estimated local average treatment effect is robust against specifications with stringent two-way fixed effects and lags of net migration as well as the government's and opposition's (excluding radical right parties) left-right position (see *Model 3*); low effective sample size around the electoral threshold merits a conservative and skeptical reading of the results as merely presenting tentative evidence. I address further robustness checks and considerations in section *4.2*

Table 2: Regression Discontinuity Estimates

	Dependent variable:		
	anti-immigration pledge-gap		
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Bias-Corrected Estimate	-2.31***	-2.77***	-2.59***
95% CI	(-2.68, -1.95)	(-2.82, -2.73)	(-3.31, -1.86)
Robust Estimate	-2.31***	-2.77***	-2.59***
95% CI	(-2.75, -1.88)	(-2.96, -2.59)	(-3.40, -1.78)
Observations	388	388	283
Effective Observations	40	40	40
Controls	No	No	Yes
Country FEs	No	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	No	No	Yes

Note: $^{*}p < 0.1;^{**}p < 0.05;^{***}p < 0.01$

The second aim of this study was to more deeply investigate heterogeneity in the overall treatment effect as

a function of the incumbent governments' ideological proximity to radical right opposition parties. *Figure 3* presents as comparison of treatment effects between the bottom quartile (*Left Government*) and top quartile (*Right Government*) of the left-right positional difference distribution between governments and radical right opposition parties. In line with **H2** I observe substantial effect heterogeneity, to the point of reversing the overall effect among radical right proximal governments. While radical right party parliamentary presence causes more left-wing governments to substantially under-deliver on anti-immigration pledges it has the opposite effect on more right-wing governments. Both effects are statistically significant at the 90% level. While these findings again are robust to stringent two-way fixed effects and a battery of controls; further reductions in the effective sample size around the electoral threshold due to sample splitting merit a conservative interpretation of the findings.

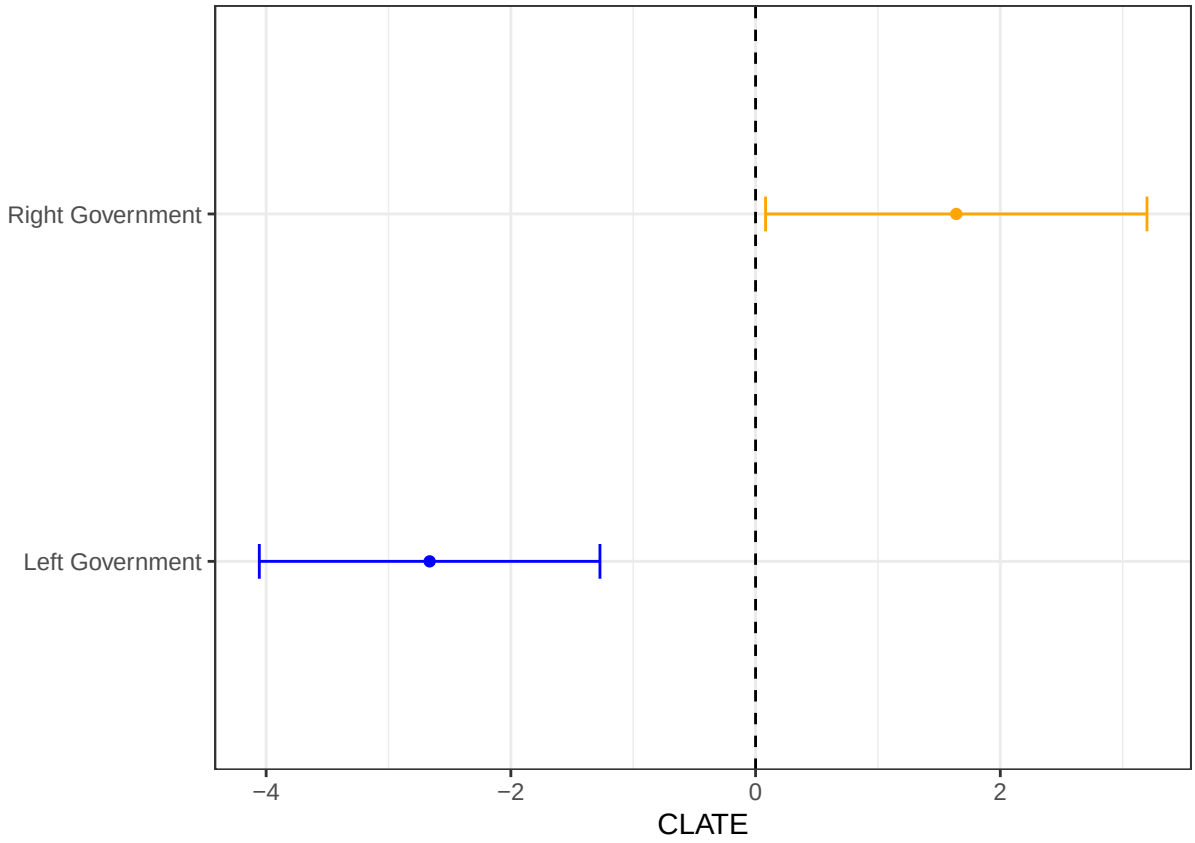


Figure 3: Treatment Effect Heterogeneity by Right Wing Ideological Proximity

4.2 Robustness

To further substantiate the validity of my RDD; I run an exhaustive set of robustness checks. Encouragingly when running a local polynomial density test (see Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma 2020), I find no evidence of sorting around the parliamentary inclusion threshold; suggesting that parties are indeed unable to precisely manipulate the threshold and thus break quasi random assignment *Appendix Fig 4*. Additionally my RDD exhibits no statistically significant treatment effects at an exhaustive set of placebo cutoffs, substantiating the assumption that a sharp discontinuity infact only exists at the parliamentary inclusion threshold *Appendix Fig*

5. The estimated treatment effects are further robust to a large set of estimation bandwidths, only becoming statistically insignificant at bandwidths exceeding 10; a threshold that is sure to produce biased estimates. Somewhat more critically; however country jackknife estimation reveals that the statistical significant negative overall treatment effect may be driven disproportionately by the inclusion of Greece, the Netherlands and Switzerland in my sample *Appendix Fig 6.* More generally estimating my full model specification excluding countries with no legally defined electoral threshold results in a statistically insignificant negative treatment effect. Both these issues reflect an overall data sparsity and external validity issue with the above analysis. Inferences presented in this paper may generalize poorly out of sample and should be considered as tentative evidence for the hypothesized effects only.

5. Conclusion

While left government retrenchment and right government accommodation in response to right-wing opposition challenges may be a somewhat mundane finding to most political scientists; the results of the above analysis are noteworthy in at least three respects. First the fact that fringe parties exert such outsized **causal** influence on government behavior runs counter to the accepted wisdom of pledge-fulfillment opposition dynamics that in order to be influential; opposition parties must represent a viable alternative to the incumbent government. The fact that a radical right wing party merely gaining a single seat in parliament induces a 2 point reduction in government pledge-fulfillment speaks volumes about the growing relevance of fringe parties in the modern political arena. Second the fact that parliamentary representation of radical right parties causes governments to under-deliver on anti-immigration policy tempers some concerns w.r.t contagion effects of radical ideology. It is clearly not a foregone conclusion that an increase in anti-immigration rhetoric necessarily translates into more restrictive immigration policy. Third the overall ideological composition of parliament is a critical determinant of party pledge fulfillment strategy. Prospective and retrospective voter reward maximization interact with positional competition in complex ways to inform parties' pledge prioritization. While the above analysis is hampered by data sparsity and external validity concerns it presents compelling tentative evidence for novel theoretical approaches to the interplay of party competition and pledge fulfillment. Future research should seek to bridge the gap between the salience / issue competition and pledge-fulfillment literature in formalizing theories on how ideological positioning and strategic incentives shape government pledge fulfillment.

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Appendix

`GitHub` link to replication materials



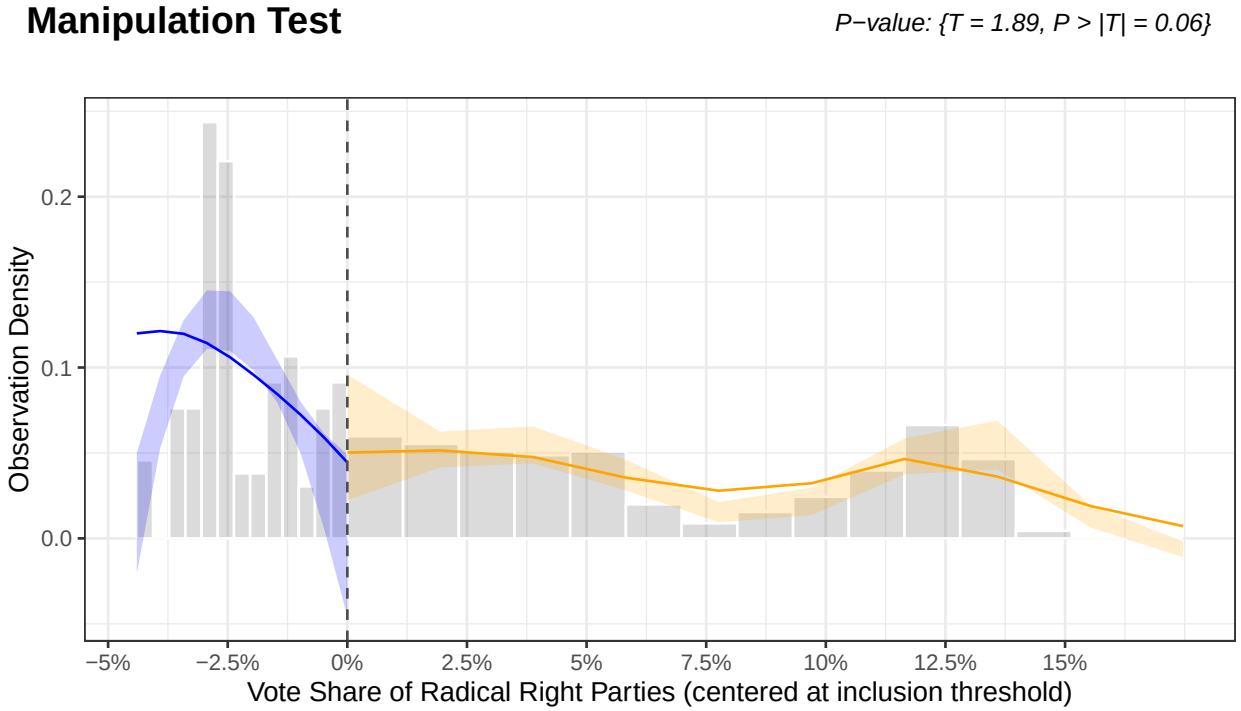


Figure 4: Treatment Assignment Manipulation Robustness

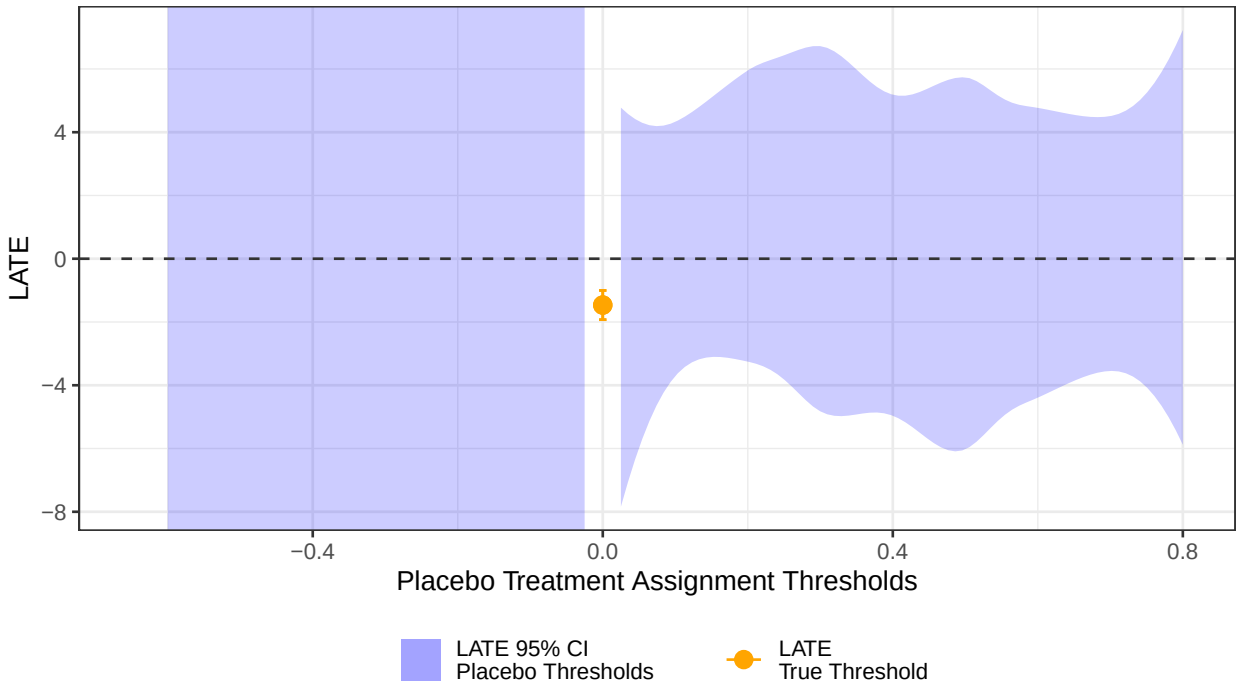


Figure 5: Placebo Cutoff Robustness

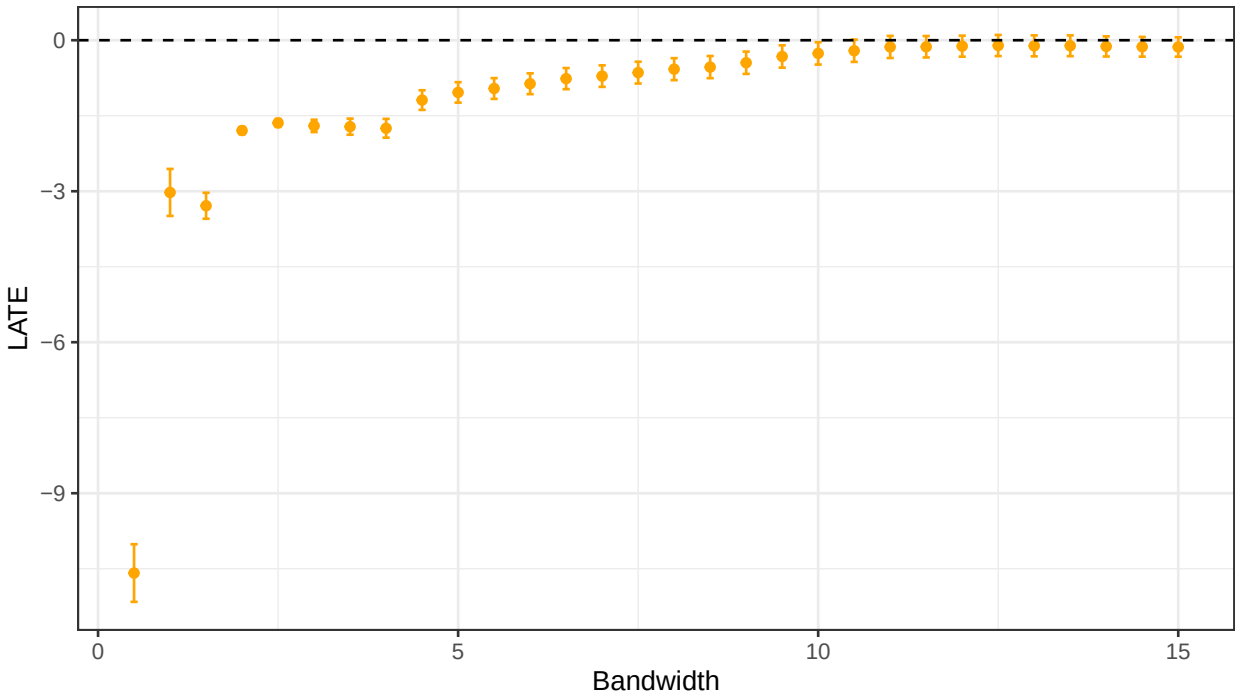


Figure 6: Bandwidth Robustness

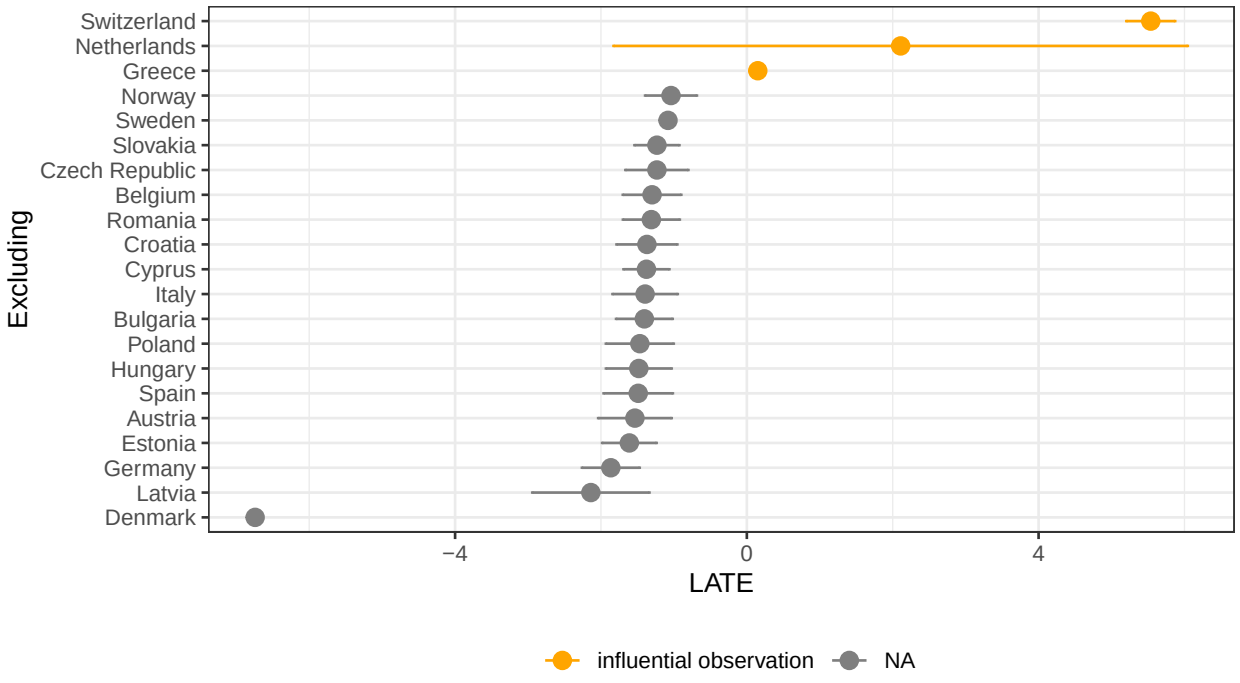


Figure 7: Influential Observations Jackknife Robustness